the matter, working toward a permanent solution, contrary to the opinion of many Israelis who supported the maintaining of the status quo. According to Eshkol, if there was going to be an “explosion,” this was the time. The longer the situation carried on, the harder it would become for Israel, he claimed. “We let the cobra get warm beneath our lap,” he said, and expressed his hope that at least someone would investigate and study the matter.

At the cabinet meeting on November 29, 1964, Abba Eban, in his capacity as deputy prime minister, reported that the refugee clause would “catch fire,” as he put it, in the General Assembly in January 1965. A worrying new development was that the Arabs were demanding recognition of the delegation to the annual discussion not as a refugee delegation but as a Palestinian delegation; there was a bloc of twenty Arab and Muslim countries that supported this demand. But there was also a ray of hope in Abba Eban’s report. In a conversation he had with the person responsible for the UN in the US Department of State, two points were raised. The first was the impatience of those in the State Department involved in the refugee issue with UNRWA’s rampant malpractices and manipulations. They were urging the new UNRWA director, Dr. Michelmore, to tighten procedures. The removal of the deceased from the list of refugees was only the first demand of him; he was also under pressure to greatly reduce the number of refugees, removing not only those who had died but also those who had been absorbed into the economies of their countries of residence. The second point was that more and more people within the State Department were in agreement that the Arabs were using the refugees as a pawn and that UNRWA was providing them with international support. The State Department’s conclusion was that the humanitarian dimension of the refugee problem had been exaggerated.

On June 17 and 19, 1967, a few days after the end of the Six-Day War, two—in my opinion pivotal—government meetings were held that dealt with the refugee issue. In hindsight, these meetings can be seen as a watershed between the nineteen years after the War of Independence and the era that began with the Six-Day War and that continues to this day.

The protocols of these meetings show the balance of power and influence around the table as follows. On one side was a group of ministers —Pinchas Sapir, Zalman Aran, Eliyahu Sasson, Mordechai Bentov, and Yisrael Yeshayahu—who viewed this as the ideal time for Israel to come up